

FINE LIVING

HOTEL

Clockwise from left: The Forestlight Luxury Villa shrouded in green; Water bodies abound as do coffee experiences amid theatrical environs, covered with dense foliage; In-villa wellness therapy at The Forestlight Luxury Villa

A WELCOME STEEPED IN COFFEE

The drive from Bengaluru takes about five hours, and the last stretch is its own decompression. As the road climbs, the air cools, and mist gathers in the valleys until the city falls by the wayside. The lobby opens beneath a soaring vault of woven bamboo, part cathedral, part forest canopy, with light filtering through its ribs. A personal butler took charge from there on, and an electric buggy carried me down the hillside to my villa. The estate is vast and the terrain dramatic, so buggies are a blessing. My villa opened onto a veranda with a private pool and views across the treetops, the kind of space where you instinctively lower your voice.

THE COFFEE RITUAL

Coffee is the Sanctuary's native language. At 92 Degrees, the coffee lounge and library, I joined a guided cupping session that traced the journey from plant to roast to pour-over. It felt like home; the ritual is kin to whisky tasting—you nose first, then taste deliberately, chase acidity, body and sweetness across the palate. The slurp replaces the swirl, but the discipline is identical. With coffee growing on the slopes outside, terroir stopped being a word and became something I could taste.

AT THE TABLE

Food is where the Sanctuary tells Coorg's story most persuasively, across four very different outlets.

Luma. The all-day restaurant sits beneath a dramatic, foliage-inspired ceiling overlooking the lake. Its live counters travel from Japan and the Levant to Europe and India, but I kept returning to the Kodava kitchen. Koli curry, fragrant and deeply spiced, mopped up with soft akki roti, is Coorg on a plate and should not be missed. One morning, breakfast arrived on a floating tray in my villa pool, gloriously indulgent, with only the Malabar giant squirrels leaping through the canopy for company.

Zen. The pan-Asian restaurant is where the kitchen shows its finesse. Thatched dining gazebos seem to hover over reflecting water, and the sound of running streams replaces background music. Plating is precise, the servers explain every ingredient with genuine care, and the desserts built around Japanese Nama chocolate are worth the trip alone.

The Cellar. Naturally, I found my way to the bar. The Cellar is an intimate bar with retro, Winchester-style seating, and what impressed me most was its restraint. Rather than importing a cocktail list from a city bar, the team reaches into the Kodava pantry. Local herbs and spices shape the drinks, and kachampuli, Coorg's dark, sour fruit vinegar, lends a savoury, tamarind-like edge that plays beautifully against a spirit's sweetness. Guests can step behind the counter for a mixology session. This is how a bar should honour its place.

92 Degrees. Beyond cupping sessions, the coffee lounge doubles as a library, the perfect spot for a lazy afternoon with a pour-over and a book while rain drums on the canopy.

DAYS WRITTEN BY THE FOREST

Mornings began with a resident naturalist, walking trails alive with Malabar giant squirrels, great hornbills, kingfishers and wild spices. The forest reveals its smaller wonders too: a foam-nest frog, a pill millipede curling into a perfect bead on your palm. The lake invites kayaking and catch-and-release fishing, and horse